national party spokesperson before being appointed cabinet minister in Nitish Kumar's NDA alliance government in Bihar in February 2021.

Table 5.1: Not Just Now, the BJP Hardly Ever Fielded Muslim Candidates in UP in the Lok Sabha Elections: BJP, Congress, BSP, SP Muslim Lok Sabha Candidates in UP (1991–2019)

Year	*BJP*	*Congress*	*BSP*	*SP*
1991	0	6	n.a.	6
1996	0	2	21	12
1998	1	10	11	10
1999	1	8	13	11
2004	2	8	20	10
2009	1	9	12	11
2014	1	9	12	15
2019	0	8	6	4

Source: Fieldwork and analysis by Mehta–Singh Social Index. Lok Sabha candidates analysed from ECI data.

The BJP was more restrained in its Hindutva idioms and symbolism in the earlier days—especially at the national level between 1996 and 2009—because it needed alliances. After 2014, under Modi, it unapologetically doubled down on Hindutva, which worked in terms of electoral winnability. Its political message now had a clear and distinctive branding. The psephologist Jai Mrug argues that, in a time of great social flux, voters are attracted to a party that has a 'clear positioning, as opposed to one that stands for many things and is a bit of this and a bit of that. Not being defensive about Hindutva helped BJP with younger voters.' It is indeed worth investigating if more strident Hindutva rhetoric earned the BJP a higher appeal among younger voters. In this context, the political scientists Rahul Varma and Pradeep Chhibber have shown through studies of voter surveys that nationalistic sentiments were